

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Book Intros)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Matthew

Matthew

Matthew shows that Jesus of Nazareth is the Messiah, also called the Christ. This means he is God's promised king of Israel, the one God sent to save his people. Jesus fulfills the promises in the Old Testament. But he also changes what many people in his time expected the Messiah to be.

The Gospel of Matthew shows how both Jews and non-Jews have a place in God's growing kingdom. It calls readers to follow Jesus Christ fully as king.

Setting

Matthew wrote his Gospel when the early Christian community faced an important question. Would it remain within Judaism, or would it become a separate faith?

Matthew's Gospel likely came from a Christian community near Jerusalem. This community lived among Jews who had not accepted Jesus as the Messiah. Unlike many Christians in Paul's churches, this community had to answer to their Jewish neighbors about how they followed the rules of Jewish law each day.

The Christians who read Matthew's Gospel had to live as Jewish Christians among Jews who were fully committed to the Torah, the law God gave Israel. The Letter of James shows a similar form of Christianity. It describes believers who were still closely connected to the synagogue, the Jewish place of worship (see James 2:1–26). This is a form of Jewish Christianity that stayed deeply committed to the Jewish community. It was also deeply committed to Jesus, the glorious Lord (compare Acts 15:1–41).

Matthew's Gospel shows how the life of Jesus affected Jewish Christians. They were dealing with questions about worship practices, Jewish law, social life, and politics. Matthew helped these early Christians answer an urgent question: "How should we follow Jesus today? And how should we do this while living among Jews and announcing the good news of the kingdom to all people?"

Summary

Matthew's story follows Jesus from before his birth until after his death and resurrection. As a child, Jesus faces several dangers (chapter 2). As an adult, Jesus begins a short public ministry. He teaches about God's righteousness, or the right way to live before

God (chapters 5–7). He also performs amazing miracles (8:1–9:34). Then he sends out the 12 apostles to continue his work (9:35–11:1).

Many Jews in Galilee and Judea reject Jesus (chapters 11–17). During his last week of life on earth, he confronts Jewish leaders in the temple (chapters 21–22). He warns the leaders who guide people in the wrong way (chapter 23). He also says that God will judge Jerusalem and that the city will be destroyed (chapters 24–25).

Jesus is arrested, put on trial, and killed by crucifixion (chapters 26–27). This happens because he opposes the Jewish leaders and challenges their power. But God shows that Jesus is right by raising him from the dead. Then Jesus gives his disciples the Great Commission. He commands them to make disciples of all nations (chapter 28).

Matthew gives his Gospel two main parts:

1. After the introduction (chapters 1–4), Matthew alternates between the teaching of Jesus and the story of his life. Jesus teaches in chapters 5–7; 10, 13, 18, 23–25. Matthew tells the story of what Jesus did in chapters 8–9; 11–12, 14–17, 19–22, 26–28.
2. Matthew shows Jesus bringing God's message to Israel. Jesus announces that God's kingdom has come near in the last days (4:12–11:1; see 4:17). Matthew then shows how different people respond to this message (11:2–20:34). After this, Matthew tells about the death and resurrection of Jesus Christ. Through Jesus, God brings salvation to all people (chapters 21–28).

Author

Matthew was a tax collector. Jesus became his friend and called him to live with justice and obedience (9:9). Matthew invited many friends to share a meal with Jesus (9:10–13). Jesus made him one of the twelve apostles (10:2–4; see also Mark 3:16–19; Luke 6:13–16; Acts 1:13).

Early church tradition says that after Matthew wrote his Gospel, he left Palestine in the AD 60s. He went to India to preach the good news about Jesus (Eusebius, Church History 3.24.6).

In the early AD 100s, Papias, the bishop of Hierapolis, wrote about Matthew's Gospel. He said, "Matthew composed the oracles in the Hebrew language [or, 'in a Hebrew style'] and each interpreted them as he was able." Many Christians have understood Papias to mean that the apostle Matthew wrote a Gospel in Hebrew or Aramaic. They also understood him to mean

that someone later translated this Gospel into Greek. This person may have known the Gospel of Mark.

Recent studies suggest another view. Papias may have meant that Matthew wrote in a Jewish style, not in Hebrew or Aramaic. This is because Matthew's Gospel does not seem to be "translation Greek," which is Greek that sounds like it was translated from another language.

In the 1800s, many scholars became convinced that Matthew used Mark's Gospel as a source. They argued that an apostle would not have used another Gospel, especially one written by someone who was not an apostle, to tell the story of the life of Jesus. For this reason, they said Matthew did not write the Gospel of Matthew.

But early church tradition connects Mark's Gospel with the apostle Peter. This makes Matthew's use of Mark easier to understand. There is no conflict if one apostle, Matthew, used the account of another apostle, Peter, as a helpful source for writing his own Gospel.

Occasion of Writing

Unlike Paul's letters or the book of Revelation, the Gospels do not tell us clearly when and where they were written. We must learn about their settings from details and themes inside the books themselves (see 24:15; 27:46; 28:15).

Matthew seems to have been written when Christians and Jews were strongly debating several questions, such as:

- How should God's law be obeyed (5:17–48; 15:1–20)?
- Who is the Messiah ("the Christ"; chapters 1–2)?
- Who are the true people of God: Israel, the church, or both (21:33–46)?
- Who are the rightful leaders of God's people (4:18–22; 10:2–4; 21:43; 23:1–36; 28:16–20)?
- How do Gentiles (non-Jews) relate to the church and to Israel (2:1–12; 3:7–10; 4:12–16; 8:5–13; 15:21–28; 28:16–20)?

Scholars still debate the setting of Matthew's Gospel. Some think Matthew came from a Christian community that was still part of Judaism. Others think this community had already separated from Judaism. Another view is that Matthew wrote for a general audience, not for one specific community. Early Christianity had many different groups. Some Christian leaders, such as James, kept a close relationship with Jewish communities for a long time.

To study this question, scholars often look at these passages: 2:1–12; 4:12–16; 8:5–13; 10:5–6; 15:21–28; 17:24–27; 19:28; 21:43; 22:7; 23:1–39.

Date and Location

Matthew was probably written between AD 65 and AD 80. Scholars who think Matthew used Mark's Gospel as a source usually date Matthew after AD 70. Scholars who think Matthew did not use Mark often date it earlier.

Some scholars have suggested that Matthew was written in the AD 50s. Many scholars today think Matthew was written in Antioch in Syria. This setting is more likely than other proposed settings.

Meaning and Message

Matthew argues that Jesus fulfills Israel's ancient faith and the hope of the Old Testament. In Jesus, the Messiah has come. The day of the Lord, the time when God acts to judge and save, has also come.

Some people do follow Jesus. As they obey his teaching, these disciples will announce the good news about Jesus across the Roman world. They will also help build the church, a community that includes both Jews and Gentiles.

But many people in Israel refuse to follow their Messiah. Jesus warns them that they will face God's judgment unless they repent (chapters 23–25).

Matthew's Gospel has several important themes. It presents Jesus as the Messiah and as a teacher. It often speaks about the kingdom of heaven. It calls people to follow Jesus faithfully as his disciples.

Matthew also shows how Jesus fulfills the Old Testament. It gives strong criticism of the Jewish religious leaders. It also shows that Gentiles have a place in God's kingdom.

The Messiah (Christ)

Matthew emphasizes that Jesus is the Messiah (1:1, 16–18; 11:2–3; 16:16, 20; 23:10). Jesus fulfills the hopes and promises of the Old Testament. But he does not fulfill them in the way many Jews in his time expected. For Matthew, Jesus is clearly the Son of God. He was born of the virgin Mary to save his people (1:21). Jesus is "Immanuel" (which means, "God with us") (1:23; 28:20).

The Kingdom of Heaven

Matthew uses the phrase kingdom of Heaven 30 times by Matthew. This phrase is a Jewish way to speak about the kingdom of God.

Matthew uses this phrase to describe several truths:

1. The kingdom of heaven is God's present rule on earth through the saving work of Jesus the Messiah.
2. God is fulfilling the promises of the Old Testament (4:17; 11:11-15).
3. God's kingdom often comes in quiet and humble ways (11:25; 13:24-30, 36-43).
4. God's kingdom shows God's power and strength (11:2-6, 12-13; 12:28).
5. The kingdom would come within a "generation" (10:23; 16:28; 24:34).
6. At the end, God will judge all people (25:31-46).
7. Then all God's holy people will live in perfect fellowship with the Father (8:11-12; 13:43; 22:1-14; 26:29).

The kingdom of heaven shows God's perfect rule through Jesus the Messiah among his people. It begins with the church and will be complete in God's eternal kingdom of glory and fellowship.

Discipleship

Matthew's Gospel emphasizes the call Jesus gives to all people to become his disciples. A disciple is someone who follows Jesus and learns from him. Jesus calls people to be baptized, obey his teaching, and live in close relationship with him (28:20). He explains what discipleship requires in the Sermon on the Mount (chapters 5-7). This theme appears throughout Matthew's Gospel (for example, 10:1-42; 16:24-26).

Matthew also shows that the disciples fail at times. But with Christ's help, they grow and continue to follow him (see 14:28-33; 16:5-12).

Fulfillment of the Old Testament

More than any other Gospel, Matthew shows how Jesus fulfills the hopes and promises of the Old Testament.

Matthew writes in a way that is similar to Jewish commentary. He connects Old Testament passages with events in the life of Jesus. These events fulfill what the Old Testament said. Matthew also often shows links between the Old Testament and the New Testament.

Matthew's method is based on this belief: what God once did in Israel, he is now doing again in Jesus Christ. In Jesus, God does this fully and finally.

Universal Outlook

Matthew's Gospel is strongly connected to Jewish life and faith. Even so, it gives strong attention to Gentiles who are included in the Messiah's saving work. More than the other Gospels, Matthew shows that the good news is for all people, including Gentiles. This view

brought Matthew into disagreement with many Jews of his time. They disagreed about two basic questions: Who are the people of God? And what future does Israel have?

The stories about the birth of Jesus show that God saves Gentiles. Throughout Matthew's Gospel, Gentiles are often shown in a positive way. God rules over all things. So his Messiah is king over all creation.

God worked in a special way in and through Israel (see 10:5-6; 15:24). But the beginning of the kingdom of heaven shares God's good favor with the nations as well (see 28:18-20).